Criminals should be given the harshest punishment, but it should be according to law. Playing with the rule of law for a political purpose is not right for a democracy"

–PRIYANKA GANDHI
Congress General Secretary In-charge for UP





Crime has reached its peak in UP and the morale of criminals is high... When someone can be killed in firing openly amid a security cordon, then what about the safety of the general public?"

–AKHILESH YADAV
Former Chief Minister, UP and President, Samajwadi Party



Uttar Pradesh has become 'Encounter Pradesh'. The Supreme Court should take cognisance of this extremely serious and worrisome situation"

MAYAWATI
Former CM, BSP supremo



Encounters have become a new normal in UP. I am shocked by the brazen anarchy and total collapse of law and order in the state"

–MAMATA BANERJEE
Chief Minister, West Bengal, and TMC chief

Sajan compresses most of it into two sentences. "Political workers, activists, even journalists get cases registered against them if they raise their voice against the government. This law-and-order narrative is fake." To prove that wrong, Yogi has to find a reasonable balance between his often contradictory political and governance imperatives, and work towards a universally persuasive narrative. That may be work in progress. But the challenge goes beyond being even-handed with the known devils of the mafia. The system itself is deeply tainted by the mafia, and there's a journey to be made beyond effigy villains. Even if the bullet that felled Atiq traced an unambiguous path, how it got to the penultimate point is the biggest mystery presently. Unless those who commissioned the hit job are brought to book by the administration, it would mean the rest of the iceberg is still intact.

Three days after Atiq Ahmed was gunned down, speaking at a public function, Yogi made what was seen as an indirect reference to the incident. "Now professional criminals or mafia cannot threaten anybody," he declared. "Before 2017, the law-and-order situation in Uttar Pradesh was bad and the state was infamous for riots. Earlier, the state faced a crisis of identity, now criminals face a crisis in the state. There have been no riots in the past six years. The rule of law prevails." Now to ensure that the principles of justice too prevail. ■

Photographs: BANDEEP SINGH, MANEESH AGNIHOTRI, ANI